

God's Sovereignty and Human Responsibility

Romans 8:28–30

“And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose.

For those God foreknew He also predestined to be conformed to the likeness of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brothers.

And those He predestined, He also called; those He called, He also justified; those He justified, He also glorified.”

This passage presents one of the great tensions in Christian theology—not because Scripture contradicts itself, but because finite minds are attempting to comprehend the workings of an infinite God. Romans 8:28–30 stands as one of Scripture's clearest declarations of God's sovereign purpose in salvation. Yet the same Bible that teaches that God foreknew, predestined, called, justified, and glorified His people also sincerely calls every sinner to repent and believe the gospel.

Scripture affirms both truths without embarrassment or apology.

Our natural tendency is to force these doctrines into a system that satisfies human logic. Some, emphasizing God's sovereignty, diminish the genuine offer of the gospel and can make human responsibility appear almost illusory. Others, determined to preserve human responsibility, weaken God's sovereign election until it becomes little more than God's foresight of human decisions.

In either case, one biblical truth is diminished in order to preserve another.

But Scripture never asks us to choose between them.

The Limits of Human Understanding

Faith is content to believe what God has revealed, even when it cannot fully explain how those truths harmonize. This is not irrational faith but humble faith. There is a vast difference between something being beyond our understanding and something being contrary to reason.

The doctrine of the Trinity, the incarnation of Christ, and the union of Christ's full deity and full humanity all transcend human comprehension, yet they are clearly revealed in Scripture and therefore believed.

The relationship between divine sovereignty and human responsibility belongs in that same category.

We should not assume that a doctrine must be fully explainable to the human mind before it can be accepted as true. If God has revealed two truths, our responsibility is to receive both—even when we cannot fully comprehend their relationship.

God's Sovereign Purpose in Salvation

Romans 8:28–30 lifts our eyes to God's eternal perspective. Before time began, He purposed to conform His people to the image of His Son.

Paul writes:

“For those God foreknew He also predestined to be conformed to the likeness of His Son.” — Romans 8:29

He then continues:

“And those He predestined, He also called; those He called, He also justified; those He justified, He also glorified.” — Romans 8:30

Every movement in this passage emphasizes God's work.

He foreknew.

He predestined.

He called.

He justified.

He glorified.

This is often called the *golden chain of redemption*. What is striking is that every link is presented as God's action. Paul's emphasis is not on the believer's ability to preserve himself but on God's purpose to complete the work He has begun.

The certainty of salvation therefore rests ultimately upon God's faithfulness.

Paul expresses this same confidence elsewhere:

“being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.” — Philippians 1:6

God's sovereign purpose gives the believer confidence that salvation is not ultimately dependent upon human strength or ability. The God who begins the work is the God who brings it to completion.

Human Responsibility and the Gospel Invitation

Yet God's sovereign purpose never negates human responsibility.

Throughout Scripture, God commands people to repent and believe. Paul declared to the Athenians:

“Although God overlooked the ignorance of earlier times, He now commands all people everywhere to repent.” — Acts 17:30

Scripture also declares:

“Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.” — Romans 10:13

The invitation of the gospel is genuine.

Jesus said:

“All that the Father gives Me will come to Me, and the one who comes to Me I will never cast out.” — John 6:37

Notice the two truths standing together in this single verse.

“All that the Father gives Me will come to Me” speaks of the Father’s sovereign giving.

“The one who comes to Me I will never cast out” extends an unfailing welcome to everyone who comes to Christ.

Jesus did not attempt to resolve the relationship between these truths philosophically. He simply proclaimed both.

The sinner is genuinely responsible for his response to the gospel. Those who reject Christ cannot rightly blame God for their unbelief. Scripture consistently treats unbelief as human guilt and calls sinners to repentance.

At the same time, those who come to Christ have every reason to recognize that their salvation ultimately rests upon the sovereign grace of God.

Faith Does Not Require Full Explanation

This is where human reason often wants to go farther than Scripture allows.

We want to know precisely how God's sovereign election relates to man's free response. We want a formula that completely explains how God's purpose and human responsibility operate together.

But Scripture does not give us such a formula.

Instead, it gives us revelation.

God is sovereign.

Man is responsible.

God calls.

Man is commanded to respond.

God saves.

Man is accountable for rejecting the Savior.

These truths may be difficult to reconcile philosophically, but they are not contradictory.

A contradiction would require Scripture to affirm that a person is both responsible and not responsible for the same action in the same sense. Scripture does not do this. Rather, it teaches God's sovereign purpose alongside genuine human responsibility.

The fact that we cannot fully explain the relationship does not make either truth less biblical.

The Gospel Must Be Proclaimed to All

This understanding has practical consequences for evangelism.

If God is sovereign, we do not need to manipulate people into salvation. We preach the gospel because God has commanded us to preach it.

If man is responsible, we do not treat the gospel invitation as meaningless. We call people to repentance and faith because God genuinely commands them to respond.

Paul illustrates this balance beautifully in his own ministry. He preached Christ openly, reasoned with people from the Scriptures, urged them to believe, and trusted God with the results.

Our responsibility is to proclaim the gospel faithfully.

God's responsibility is to save.

As Paul wrote:

"I planted the seed and Apollos watered it, but God made it grow." — 1 Corinthians 3:6

The farmer plants and waters, but the life and growth come from God.

That is an appropriate picture of Christian ministry. We proclaim. God gives life.

A Mystery That Should Produce Worship

There is a temptation to approach divine sovereignty and human responsibility merely as an intellectual puzzle. But Scripture leads us somewhere higher.

After spending Romans 9–11 dealing with God's sovereign purposes, Paul does not end with a philosophical explanation. He ends in worship:

“Oh, the depth of the riches of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable His judgments, and untraceable His ways!” — Romans 11:33

Paul does not apologize for the mystery.

He worships.

That should also be our response.

God has revealed enough for us to believe, trust, obey, and proclaim. He has not revealed everything necessary for us to comprehend His eternal counsels exhaustively.

There is humility in recognizing that distinction.

We are creatures attempting to understand the purposes of our Creator. We should therefore be cautious about declaring impossible what Scripture declares true simply because we cannot fit it completely within our understanding.

“I Never Reconcile Friends”

Charles Haddon Spurgeon expressed this beautifully in his sermon *High Doctrine and Broad Doctrine*:

No, I never reconcile friends.

Whether or not the statement can be traced with certainty to a particular occasion, the thought captures an important biblical principle: divine sovereignty and human responsibility do not need to be made enemies before they can be reconciled.

Scripture presents them together.

We should therefore resist the temptation to resolve the tension by eliminating one of the truths.

God's sovereignty does not make human responsibility meaningless.

Human responsibility does not diminish God's sovereignty.

Instead, both truths magnify the wisdom and majesty of God.

Conclusion

Romans 8:28–30 gives the believer a breathtaking view of salvation from God’s eternal perspective. God foreknew, predestined, called, justified, and glorified His people. Salvation rests upon His sovereign purpose and His faithfulness to complete the work He began.

Yet Scripture never uses God's sovereignty as a reason to weaken the gospel invitation.

God commands all people everywhere to repent. He calls sinners to believe. He promises that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord will be saved. Jesus promises that the one who comes to Him will never be cast out.

These truths stand together.

We do not need to solve what God has chosen to reveal as a mystery. We need to believe what He has revealed.

God is sovereign.

Man is responsible.

Christ is offered freely to all.

God alone saves.

These truths do not diminish one another. They drive us to humility, confidence, evangelism, and worship.

God’s sovereignty gives the believer assurance that salvation rests upon God’s eternal purpose rather than human weakness. Human responsibility gives urgency to the proclamation of the gospel and leaves every person accountable for his response to Christ.

We therefore preach Christ freely to all because God commands us to do so, and we rest confidently in His sovereign grace because God alone can save.

The believer’s task is not to improve upon God’s revelation, but to **believe it, proclaim it, and rejoice in it.**